

The logistics of tank deployment

The movement of tanks can be divided into three categories; strategic, operational and tactical, and battlefield. At the strategic level, there is the movement of tanks from barracks or stores to the area of operations, which can mean transportation to a different continent. Two Abrams tanks, for example, can be transported in a C5 Galaxy aircraft, but the usual way is by road transporter or by train to a port and a roll-on roll-off ship. Indeed, the use of railroads to move tanks has had a considerable influence on tank design. In Europe, the Berne International Load Gauge deemed that a maximum width of 3.5 m could safely be carried on most European railroads—but in Britain, the rail loading gauge was narrower at 2.67 m.

At the operational level, i.e. in areas where combat may occur, problems may include road and bridge restrictions, the risk of damage to urban areas, and the distance a tank may have to drive—the greater the distance, the greater both the fuel requirement and the likelihood of breakdown. On the battlefield, the immediate ground will influence a tank's mobility, and may limit the way it can operate. Speed may help a tank become a harder target to hit—or thicker armor may make it less vulnerable—and so it can choose its route across a battlefield with impunity.

M1A2 Abrams tanks and M2A3 Bradley IFVs arrive at Busan in South Korea from Texas to boost South Korean defenses in February 2014.

